

Dreamers, challengers and a giant

India enters the Women's Asia Cup as the team to beat, while the rest of the field searches for a way to **close the gap.**

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Meet the contenders



Group A

India, Pakistan, Thailand, Hong Kong China

Group B

Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, UAE, Indonesia

In 2024, when Harshitha Samarawickrama and Kavisha Dilhari fought their way to a famous victory over India in the Asia Cup, optimists hoped for a new dawn in Asian women's cricket, however naive that sounds. Captain Chamari Athapaththu watched from the sidelines as her young dreamers took charge of an audacious heist.

The fire from that win in Dambulla spread across the nation and galvanised energy within the ecosystem, with troves of fresh talent wanting to be the next Chamari, Kavisha, or Harshitha.

Two years and three World Cups later, the wet blanket of reality has effectively doused the last ember, underlining that as much as things change, the big picture often remains the same.

The 2026 Women's Asia Cup will get underway from August 28 to September 13 at the Dubai International Cricket Stadium. India, Sri Lanka, Pakistan and Bangladesh will be joined by host UAE, Thailand, Indonesia and Hong Kong China, who qualified by virtue of finishing as the top four teams in the 18-team ACC Women's Premier Cup held in June.

As teams gear up for a continental challenge that will serve as good preparation, especially for the sides heading to the Asian Games in Japan a few weeks later, the theme on the chalkboard has gone back to "Who will meet India in the final?" A skewed



Chasing eighth: Seven-time champion India, led by Harmanpreet Kaur and Smriti Mandhana (front), is the overwhelming favourite this edition. However, the side will be without star batter Jemimah Rodrigues (extreme right), who is sidelined by injury.

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